

Rehabilitation Admission Process

Internal policy / SOP - for demo purposes only

1. Purpose

This procedure describes the admission process for short-term rehabilitation residents, including eligibility criteria, intake documentation, and the coordination of therapy services.

2. Eligibility for Short-Term Rehabilitation

A resident is eligible for short-term rehabilitation admission when all of the following are met: (a) qualifying hospital stay of at least three consecutive midnights within the prior 30 days OR a documented need for skilled rehab not requiring a hospital stay; (b) physician certification that the resident requires skilled physical, occupational, or speech therapy at least five days per week; (c) reasonable expectation that the resident will demonstrate measurable functional improvement within 60 days; (d) prior authorization from the payer source (Medicare, Medicare Advantage, or commercial insurance).

3. Pre-Admission Screening

The admissions coordinator shall obtain and review the following before accepting an admission: hospital discharge summary, current medication list, recent therapy notes, current vital signs, and any active orders. The clinical reviewer (RN or DON) must confirm that the facility can safely manage the resident's care needs.

4. Intake on Admission Day

On admission day, the admitting nurse must complete: physical assessment within four hours, fall-risk assessment, skin assessment with documented baseline, medication reconciliation, diet order verification, and identification of any allergies. The resident and family must receive an orientation to the room, call light, and facility services.

5. Therapy Evaluation

Physical therapy, occupational therapy, and speech-language pathology evaluations shall be initiated within 48 hours of admission. Each discipline determines whether the resident meets the medical-necessity criteria for ongoing skilled services. PT, OT, and ST treatment plans must be incorporated into the resident's comprehensive care plan within 14 days.

6. PT Approval Workflow

Physical therapy services require: physician order, PT evaluation, prior-authorization submission to the payer, and approval of authorized session count. Pending authorization may delay onset of skilled PT; in such cases, supportive therapy may be initiated under alternative billing. Once approved, the authorized session count and expiration date are documented in the resident's record.

7. Discharge Planning

Discharge planning begins at admission. The interdisciplinary team meets weekly to review progress against functional goals and to identify the projected discharge destination. A safe discharge requires: clinical stability, achievement of measurable functional goals, completion of caregiver education, durable medical equipment arranged at the discharge destination, and follow-up appointments scheduled.

8. Documentation Requirements

All admission documentation must be completed within 14 days of admission. The comprehensive care plan,

including therapy goals, fall-risk classification, medication regimen, and discharge plan, must be reviewed at every interdisciplinary team meeting and signed by the attending physician.